text and speak often. He's a great guy, despite the well-documented controversies, and will, I'm sure, respond positively to the fame generated by his contribution to the World Cup win. Conversations about cricket are the glue in our relationship; his commitment to the England team is total.

Friends outside the game who have gone the traditional route, through public school, university and the City, have probably missed out on that type of connection. I see them as much as I can, but it is inevitable that contrasting lifestyles make that difficult. As I began to make my way in the game my horizons were narrower, because I was concentrating on the stepping stones of professional sport.

As an emerging pro I wanted the perks of the trade, the personalized car-parking space and the sponsored car with my name signwritten on the driver's door. Needless to say, I got neither. They took parking privileges away as a result of one of those fathomless health-and-safety orders. The personalized sponsored car, which first seized my imagination when I saw Peter Such drive past me, went out of fashion.

Not a bad thing, all told, because, in hindsight, they looked ridiculous. I settled for a locker, given to county players, but it took time to wean myself off my dodgy car habit. The stick I received for one aberration of taste and decency, a bright orange Ford Focus, was unrelenting and entirely deserved.

The dressing room began to school me with its brutal humour. Even to this day I'm known as Woggle, because of my slightly wonky left eye. It can lead to some horrendous still photographs when I'm concentrating on my batting, since I appear cross-eyed. I get hammered left, right and centre, from senior players and kids alike. You must be big enough to take it, if you want to give it out.

Cricket tends to attract a broader base of personalities than, say, rowing, where a successful eight tends to come from a similar demographic and is more interconnected. A cricket team can overcome individual errors but if one oarsman catches a crab during a race it's all over. As an established Test batsman, I could survive a short run of very low scores and still win a series through the efforts of others.

That helps to create a distinctive tolerance within the dressing room. It is an enlightening environment, because you unconsciously, or even consciously, reveal aspects of your character within it. What makes it so special is that teammates see everything of you, and share your struggle, without the outside world knowing anything of it.